



HACKATHON

KICKOFF

JUNE 14, 2026

Build Real-World AI.
Compete Globally.
Hack Your Future in AI.

Presented by USAII®

aihackathon.usaii.org

Today's Kickoff — 30 Minutes



USAII Introduction

Who we are & why this matters



Keynote

Inspiration from USAII CEO



Hackathon Overview

Rules, tracks, and what to expect



Timeline & Milestones

Key dates — today through June 27



Platform Deep-Dive

Devpost · Discord · Mentors · Builder Series



Judging & Awards

\$15K+ prize pool — how winners are selected



Challenge Reveal

Your mission starts NOW

The United States Artificial Intelligence Institute

USAII® is a leading AI credentialing and education organization — advancing responsible AI literacy across industries, governments, and institutions worldwide.

Powerful

Professionals
Certifications.



Self-Paced

Disrupting



Specializations.



K-12 Programs.

OPENING KEYNOTE



Dr Milton Mattox, CEO

USAI

The USAII Global AI Hackathon

The **USAII® Global AI Hackathon** is our commitment to the next generation: helping students around the world build meaningful AI, compete on a global stage, and enter the workforce AI-ready.

6,000+

Pre-Registered

73

Countries

\$15K+

Prize Pool

200+

Mentors & Judges

5,761

Started Qualifier

2,284

Advancing

808

Teams Qualified

72%

Average Score

What Is This Hackathon?

- ✓ Fully virtual & global — students from 65+ countries competing together
- ✓ Build real AI solutions grounded in ethical principles
- ✓ Teams of 2–5 using public, synthetic, or open-source data
- ✓ No prior hackathon experience required — no-code and low-code welcome
- ✓ Supported by 120+ industry professional mentors and 80+ expert judges
- ✓ Evaluated on thinking and design, not just technical polish

19 Expert Sessions. On-Demand. Free.

Build & Pitch	AI Systems	AI Product & UX	Responsible AI	Careers & Future
From Idea to AI Product Pranav Saji · Symosis Security	From ETL to AI Systems: Intelligent Data Pipelines Jimish J Kadakia · Snowflake	A Human-Centered Approach to AI Shannon Lewandowski · Ingage Partners	From Prototype to Trust: Responsible AI Jofia Jose Prakash · American Council Ethical AI	What Does It Mean to Build with AI in 2026 Sandesh Kerehali · Meta
From Hackathon Idea to Real-World AI Impact Todd James · Aurora Insights	The Hard Truth About AI Agents in Production Rajesh Gupta · Skan AI	The Human Side of Data: Heart in AI Solutions Kiran Mayi Hari Babu · Workera	A Democracy Risk Score: Political Language & AI Anne-Elisabeth Courrier · Emory Center for Ethics	AI Made Simple: Foundations for the Next Generation Farhan Azim Auro noy · Sarva
From Idea to Impact: Building & Pitching AI Projects Kashif Saleem · SubscriptionFlow	From Classroom to Career: AI System Architecture Nehal Sangoi · AWS	Accessible by Design: Inclusive AI-Powered UIs Niharika Pujari · McGraw Hill	Sovereign AI: Privacy-First Autonomous Agents Akhmad Khudri · Universitas Bina Darma	
From Idea to Impact: Building & Pitching AI Projects Venkat Srinidhi Vaddy · Stripe	Architecting Trust: Enterprise Rigor & GenAI Juhi Deshkar · Google DeepMind	Evals, Edge Cases & Earning Trust Nivedita Thapa · Yellowbrick Data		
Rapid Prototyping in the Age of AI Shereen Moussa · PepsiCo	Building Trustworthy AI Systems Aman Bakshi · Apple			

Three Tracks. One Mission.



HIGH SCHOOL

Grades 9–12

AI for Everyday Good

Community, environment, and everyday life challenges.

1-week sprint with guided structure & mentorship.

Qualified

321 Teams with 906 Students



UNDERGRADUATE

College

AI for Life & Work

Career readiness, productivity, and public services.

1-week deep build with real nonprofit challenges.

Qualified

427 Teams with 1,254 Students



GRADUATE

Masters & PhD

AI for Systems & Society

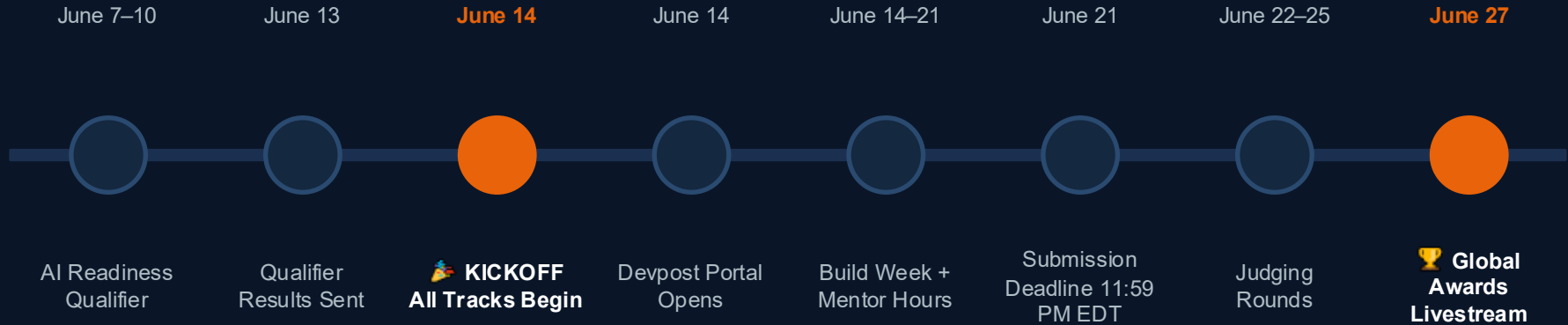
Public policy, human safety, and responsible AI infrastructure.

1-week advanced systems build.

Qualified

60 Teams with 166 Students

Key Dates — June 2026



Rules & Eligibility

- ✓ Teams of 2–5 students
- ✓ Multi-school & multi-country teams welcome
- ✓ All three tracks: June 14–21 build window
- ✓ High School = Grades 9–12
- ✓ Mixed-level teams → highest track
- ✓ No-code and low-code projects accepted
- ✗ Working professionals not eligible
- ✗ Projects must be built during the window
- ✗ No pre-built or recycled submissions
- ⚠ Disclose all AI tools & data sources
- ⚠ No harmful, illegal, or discriminatory systems
- ⚠ Ineligible winners → prize moves to next team

Two Platforms. Both Required.

DEVPOST

Official Competition Platform

- Create project
- Add teammates
- Submit your project by June 21 11:59 pm ET
- View judging results after June 27 10:00 am ET

usaii-global-ai-hackathon-2026.devpost.com

DISCORD

Community & Communication Hub

- Announcements & updates
- Track-specific channels
- Mentor connections & Q&A
- Team formation support

discord.gg/ePjenJnyh4

Devpost

DEVPOST

Join a hackathon ▾

Host a hackathon ▾

Resources ▾

🔍

🔔

👤 ▾

USAII® UNITED STATES ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE INSTITUTE

USAII® Global AI Hackathon 2026

USAII's Global AI Hackathon 2026

Overview

My projects

Participants (5822)

Resources

Rules

Project gallery

Updates

Discussions

Manage

USAII® Global AI Hackathon 2026

(* REGISTRATION EXPIRED JUNE 6 11:59 PM ET *) A global virtual AI hackathon empowering students to build solutions for real-world good—from everyday impact to career readiness.

Find teammates

Who can participate

- Ages 14+ only
- Students only
- Team required: 2 to 5 members
- Companies/professional organizations excluded from participation

View full rules

- All countries/territories, excluding [standard exceptions](#)
- High School, College, and Graduate Students only

• Submissions open soon

View schedule

Jun 14 – 21, 2026

🌐 Online

🏠 Public

\$15,000 in cash

5822 participants

🇺🇸 USAII

🏠 Beginner Friendly

🧠 Machine Learning/AI

🌱 Social Good

Discord

The screenshot shows the Discord interface for the "USAII Global AI Hackathon 2026 - Global Virtual Hackathon" server. The left sidebar displays the server's channel list, including "welcome-start-here", "announcements", "schedule-and-links", "rules-and-faq", "usaii-global-ai-builder-series", "help-desk", "tech-support", "qualifier-resources", "hackathon-resources", "qualifier-support", "grad-general", "grad-team-formation", and "grad-challenge-public-systems-...". The main channel view is for "# welcome-start-here", which has a title "Hackathon" and a description "This is the beginning of this server." The channel contains several messages from the bot "MarciUSAII", including a welcome message, a pinned message, and a message about selecting a track. The bottom of the interface shows the user "MarciUSAII" is online and the message input area.

USAII Global AI Hackathon 2026 - Global Virtual Hackathon

welcome-start-here · React below to select your role and unlock your track channels

in: #help-desk solo

Hackathon

This is the beginning of this server.

April 23, 2026

MarciUSAII 4/23/26, 2:37 PM

USAII GLOBAL AI HACKATHON 2026

Welcome! You're in the right place.

This server is your hub for announcements, mentor support, and community connection during the hackathon.

All registrations and project submissions happen on Devpost (link in [# schedule-and-links](#) — not here).

START HERE: React below to unlock your track channels.

👍 204 😊 32 ❤️ 69 💬 19 😄 20 🏛️ 36 😊 11 ❤️ 3 🌟 1 🗨️

MarciUSAII pinned a message to this channel. See all [pinned messages](#). 4/23/26, 2:37 PM

❤️ 16 🗨️

MarciUSAII 4/23/26, 4:34 PM

React below to select your track and unlock your channels.
(📱 On mobile? TAP AND HOLD an emoji below to select your track.)

🎓 High School Participant
🏛️ College Participant
🎓 Graduate Participant (edited)

🎓 424 🏛️ 483 🎓 125 👍 47 ❤️ 14 😊 7 ✅ 5 🌟 4 🗨️

MarciUSAII Online

Message #welcome-start-here

120+ Mentors Across 3 Time Zones

Mentors guide your thinking — they don't build for you. Expect honest, practical advice from active industry professionals.



Americas

10:00–11:30 am ET
6:00–7:30 pm ET

Daily sessions



EMEA

10:00–11:30 am GMT
5:00–6:30 pm GMT

Daily sessions



APAC

10:00–11:30 am IST
5:00–6:30 pm IST

Daily sessions

What mentors help with:

Problem Framing

AI Architecture

Responsible AI

Pitch Coaching

Office Hours (2×/day)

Mentors provide guidance and thinking support only — they do not build, code, or complete work for teams.

What You Must Submit — Devpost

Portal opens June 14 · Deadline June 21, 11:59 PM ET · Submit via Devpost

	Project Description	What you built and why — clear framing
	2–5 Minute Demo Video	Show your solution in action
	AI Architecture Explanation	How your AI components actually work
	Responsible AI Guardrail	One realistic risk + one concrete design mitigation
	Human-in-the-Loop Design	Identify where humans stay in control and why
	Decision Impact Statement	Before vs. after — what changes for the user
	Tool & Data Disclosure	Every AI tool and data source used

How Judging Works

ROUND 1



AI Screening

Submissions scored automatically
against 5-dimension rubric

ROUND 2



Expert Judges

80+ industry judges
10 teams each
15 min/team = 3 hours

ROUND 3



Final Panel

Top 10 per track
5-judge panel
10 teams · 30 min = 5 hours

Judging Dimensions:

Problem Understanding

AI Reasoning

Solution Architecture

Impact & Decision Value

Responsible AI

PRIZES

\$15,000+ Prize Pool + USAI AI Certification Scholarships



Award	High School 	Undergraduate 	Graduate 
Grand Prize	\$2,500 + Scholarship	\$2,500 + Scholarship	\$2,500 + Scholarship
Runner Up	\$1,500 + Scholarship	\$1,500 + Scholarship	\$1,500 + Scholarship
Third Place	\$500 + Scholarship	\$500 + Scholarship	\$500 + Scholarship
Responsible AI	\$250 + Scholarship	\$250 + Scholarship	\$250 + Scholarship
Social Impact	\$250 + Scholarship	\$250 + Scholarship	\$250 + Scholarship

Each track award: 5 categories · \$5,000 per track · Total pool \$15,000+

Program Integrity & Fairness

- ✓ AI-generated submissions are screened for duplication across all entries
- ✓ All AI tools and data sources must be fully disclosed on Devpost
- ✓ Projects must be created within the June 14–21 build window
- ✓ No team gains advantage from time zone, live availability, or paid tools
- ✓ Prohibited: harmful, illegal, discriminatory, or dangerous systems
- ✓ Ineligible prize winners → prize awarded to next-best team



CHALLENGE REVEAL



Your mission begins now.

Six challenge briefs · Three tracks · One goal: build AI that matters

Choose Your Mission Lane

BRIEF 1

Community

"Help is Hard to Find" — Make Support Obvious

Design AI tools that help people find support, understand information, and feel confident asking for help.

Challenge Directions:

- Direction A: Crisis-to-Action Translator
- Direction B: Rumor vs. Reality Tracker

BRIEF 2

Environment

"Make Climate Action Local & Real" — Tools People Use

Make environmental impact visible and local action practical, measurable, and engaging.

Challenge Directions:

- Direction A: Food Waste Rescue Radar
- Direction B: My School's Hidden Footprint

Community

Your Mission

Build an AI-powered MVP that helps students, families, or community members find or understand support more clearly. Choose ONE direction below:

Direction A: Crisis-to-Action Translator

Turn confusing or stressful information into plain language, a checklist, and clear next steps.

- Translate complex documents into simple explanations
- Identify what matters most for the user
- Guide users toward the right immediate action
- **Examples:** School notices, government letters, hospital discharge instructions, food assistance forms, housing eligibility documents

Direction B: Rumor vs. Reality Tracker

Help people evaluate local claims and understand what is true, misleading, or unverified.

- Check claims against credible sources
- Explain why something is trustworthy, misleading, or unverified
- Help users make informed decisions under uncertainty
- **Examples:** School threat rumors, unsafe product claims, disaster misinformation, local service closures
-  **Note:** Direction B is more advanced. A simplified approach — flagging claims for human review rather than auto-verifying — is completely valid.

Environment

Your Mission

Build an AI-powered MVP that helps a school, community group, or local organization understand their environmental impact and take practical action. Choose ONE direction below:

Direction A: Food Waste Rescue Radar

Predict where food waste is likely to happen and suggest practical ways to reduce, redistribute, or better manage it.

- Identify patterns that lead to waste
- Predict when waste is likely to occur
- Suggest realistic, actionable interventions
- **Examples:** School cafeterias, events, grocery/donation programs, over-ordering patterns, leftover redistribution opportunities

Direction B: My School's Hidden Footprint

Help a school understand and visualize how everyday choices contribute to environmental impact.

- Make environmental impact visible and understandable
- Show how specific behaviors affect outcomes
- Help users prioritize the actions with the highest impact
- **Examples:** Energy use, water use, trash and recycling patterns, transportation habits, food consumption

Choose Your Mission Lane

BRIEF 3

Productivity

Build the "Second Brain" for Real Life

Help people make better decisions, manage overload, and turn complexity into clear action.

Challenge Directions:

- Direction A: Life Decision Simulator
- Direction B: Zero-to-One Builder

BRIEF 4

Public Services

Fix Systems People Depend On

Make essential systems — housing, benefits, healthcare — easier to understand and navigate.

Challenge Directions:

- Direction A: Benefits Navigator
- Direction B: Housing Stability Guide

Productivity

Your Mission

Build an AI-powered MVP that helps students, early professionals, or creators process complexity and make better decisions — or turn ideas into action. Choose ONE direction below:

Direction A: Life Decision Simulator

Help a person compare major life or career paths by modeling tradeoffs, surfacing hidden considerations, and showing likely outcomes.

- This is NOT a simple pros/cons list — help users reason with structure and confidence
- Model different scenarios and surface hidden tradeoffs
- Help users explore 'what happens if...' questions
- **Examples:** Graduate school vs. job vs. startup, moving cities for work, comparing career pathways, degree vs. bootcamp vs. self-taught

Direction B: Zero-to-One Builder

Help someone turn an early-stage idea into a realistic execution plan.

- This is NOT just a task generator — help users move from vague idea → structured plan → first real step
- Clarify the idea and identify key assumptions and risks
- Break work into milestones and guide toward a first prototype or pilot
- **Examples:** Startup idea → MVP roadmap, class project → pilot plan, big ambition → 30/60/90-day execution steps

Public Service

Your Mission

Build an AI-powered MVP that helps individuals, families, or community organizations better understand and navigate a public or social support system. Choose ONE direction below:

Direction A: Benefits Navigator

Help people understand whether they may qualify for a public support program — and what steps to take next.

- This is NOT just a directory of programs — help users interpret rules and reduce confusion
- Translate eligibility criteria into plain language
- Ask relevant questions to guide the user through their situation
- **Examples:** Food assistance, childcare support, education/training benefits, healthcare, emergency relief eligibility

Direction B: Housing Stability Guide

Help renters or housing-vulnerable users understand their options and next steps when facing housing instability.

- This is NOT legal advice — help users understand pathways and take action early
- Surface available options and resources based on the user's situation
- Guide users toward immediate, practical next steps
- **Examples:** Eviction information, rental assistance programs, housing rights education, service referrals, crisis planning checklists

Choose Your Mission Lane

BRIEF 5

Human Safety & Protection

Build AI Systems That Protect People

Detect risks earlier, strengthen protection networks, and support safer intervention strategies for vulnerable populations.

Challenge Directions:

- Direction A: AI Against Digital Exploitation
- Direction B: Economic Recovery Pathways for Survivors

BRIEF 6

Public Systems & Policy

Help Communities Make Better Decisions

Model outcomes, simulate policy interventions, and help institutions make evidence-based decisions.

Challenge Directions:

- Direction A: The Cost of Doing Nothing Simulator
- Direction B: Community AI Readiness Blueprint

Human Safety & Protection

Your Mission

Design an AI-powered system that transforms fragmented signals into actionable, explainable, and privacy-preserving decision support for human operators. Choose ONE direction below:

Direction A: Safe Passage — AI Against Digital Exploitation

Design an AI system that detects patterns associated with digital exploitation, grooming, sextortion, or coercion — while preserving privacy.

- **This is NOT surveillance** — focus on early-warning signals and responsible detection for organizational users (analysts, investigators)
- Identify patterns across behavioral or contextual signals without exposing sensitive personal data
- Support human investigators with explainable, auditable insights
- **Possible approaches:** Pattern detection across digital interaction signals, early-warning risk scoring models, XAI interfaces for investigators
- Partner inspiration: Safe Place and Protect Us Kids (We-Rise Initiative) · Safe Passages · Thorn · International Justice Mission

Human Safety & Protection

Direction B: Survivor Care — Economic Recovery Pathways

Design an AI system that helps survivors of exploitation identify realistic pathways toward long-term economic stability.

- Survivors face real constraints: limited employment history, restricted mobility, trauma-related challenges
- Identify viable pathways and map skills, transitions, and training options
- Support decision-making for survivor support organizations — not automated decisions for individuals
- **Possible approaches:** Constraint-aware career matching, skill recovery mapping, workforce pathway simulations, decision-support tools
- Partner inspiration: Institute for Survivor Care · Polaris Project · National Center for Missing & Exploited Children



Recommended Architecture Layer: Data → Governance → Intelligence → Decision → Human Action → Feedback

Strong solutions define each layer and explain how they connect. This is a useful scaffold — not required structure.

Public Systems & Policy

Your Mission

Design an AI-powered system that helps institutions analyze complex societal challenges, simulate outcomes, and support better decision-making. Choose ONE direction below:

Direction A: The Cost of Doing Nothing Simulator

Model the long-term social and economic cost of delayed or absent intervention.

- Help decision-makers explore: what happens if intervention is delayed?
- Show how risks compound over time and quantify the cost of inaction
- Support scenario planning: 'if we invest X now vs. in 5 years, what is the projected difference?'
- **Possible domains:** Homelessness, workforce development, early childhood education, public health intervention
- Partner inspiration: St. John Center for Homeless Men · Depaul International · Community Solutions (Built for Zero)

Direction B: Community AI Readiness Blueprint

Help communities assess their readiness for the AI era and build a strategic adoption roadmap.

- Identify AI readiness levels across sectors: education, workforce, healthcare, government, nonprofits
- Surface gaps in digital access, AI literacy, and infrastructure
- Recommend priority investments for long-term resilience
- **Possible outputs:** AI readiness scorecards, sector dashboards, strategic roadmaps, policy recommendations
- Partner inspiration: OECD · World Bank · Brookings Institution · Cincy AI Catalyst · African Institute for Development Policy

REAL-WORLD PARTNERS

Challenge Advisors — Real Problems, Real Stakes



Our challenges are grounded in real nonprofit partners tackling urgent societal problems. Their missions shape what students build.

Safe Passages

Child safety & trafficking prevention

Graduate Brief 5

Institute for Survivor Care

Survivor services, care innovation & coordination

Graduate Brief 5

St. John Center

Homelessness, housing stability & employment

Graduate Brief 6

Protect Us Kids Foundation

Online child exploitation prevention (8 countries)

Graduate Brief 5

Thank You to Our Sponsors

Forward-thinking organizations committed to responsible AI, workforce readiness, and student innovation.

ETA

joineta.org

Supports entrepreneurship through acquisition and next-generation business leadership. Connecting emerging AI talent with practical pathways into entrepreneurship.

The Innovate Summit

theinnovatesummit.com

Brings together founders, technologists, and thought leaders. Strengthens the bridge between student builders and the broader innovation community.

NowSourcing

nowsourcing.com

Leading digital media and data storytelling firm known for translating complex topics into accessible, visual insights.

You're In. Now Build.

1

Open Devpost to build Challenge Submission

Create your project and add team members now → usaii-global-ai-hackathon-2026.devpost.com

2

Use Discord to communicate with Mentors

Get into your track channel & say hello → discord.gg/ePjenJnyh4

3

Read the Challenge Briefs

Full challenge briefs now live → aihackathon.usaii.org

4

Select your Challenge and start Planning

Start with “Problem Canvas” and “Build a winning AI project” resources pinned in Discord [#hackathon-resources](#)

5

Start Building

You have 7 days. First mentor sessions begin today. Mentors are ready.



BUILD SOMETHING THAT MATTERS.

The world needs AI built with care,
curiosity, and purpose.
You have seven days. Make them count.

Good luck from the entire USAI team. 🚀

usaii.org

aihackathon.usaii.org